

AI REALITY CHECK

**Same company.
Two stories.
One is a pitch.**

Their marketing says you can do the work of twenty people alone.

Their job listings say otherwise.

The first story is not lying.

- AI tools have compressed real work categories. Draft, edit, summarize, analyze.
- A solo operator today can do work that used to require a team.
- The self-serve category expanded. That part is accurate.

It just left something out.

The demo is frictionless. The deployment is not.

Data in the wrong format. Permissions misconfigured. Output that looks right until something downstream breaks. Team still doing the step manually because nobody redesigned it.

That gap is the implementation layer. It was in the second story the whole time.

SELF-SERVE COLUMN

Some tasks are genuinely yours to run now.

- | Low-stakes output you can verify yourself

- | Data that is already clean

- | Process that needs no redesign to plug a tool in

Start these this week. Accept some friction. Get better at them.

IMPLEMENTATION COLUMN

The tool does not know your business.

- It does not know which data is trustworthy
- It does not know the three exceptions nobody documented
- It does not know the team habit that makes certain output invisible

A better prompt does not fix those things.

The vendors know this. That is why they hired the team.

They have separate teams for selling the demo and fixing the deployment. The marketing came from one team. The implementation engineers came from what the other team learned.

The two stories were never in conflict. They were describing different layers.

THE TWO-COLUMN SORT

One list. Two columns. Per quarter.

Column one: tasks that are self-serve now

Start this week. Own them.

Column two: everything else

Decide if it needs cleanup upstream, or if it genuinely needs help.

Knowing which is which before you build saves months.

full/REFIT

Get the DIY-versus-Help boundary worksheet.

Walks through the two-column sort for your specific tasks. Takes fifteen minutes. Tells you where to apply your own time and where to ask for something more.

Get the free worksheet

(Link in the first comment)